



Deep-cleaning, but online

China will clean up social media networks and video-sharing sites having fraudulent material.
<https://digit.in/jan22-51>



You cannot run away

According to new legislation, debt collectors can now contact US citizens via social media.
<https://digit.in/jan22-52>

ASLEEP

Future feature is our attempt at science fiction writing. You too can be featured, just write something original and creative and send it to us at magazine@digit.in

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I awake with a start. Instantly jolted into hyperawareness.

I listen carefully, my left hand secure-

ly holding on to the locket suspended around my neck, my right hand groping in the dark for the long-bladed knife I'd found yesterday. "How could I fall asleep?", I thought, angry at myself. I was always a snorer, and the silence of the night is not a time for someone like me to be asleep.

I sit there frozen for what feels like an eternity, or about 3 minutes in old world time. Nothing. I hear nothing, and that is a relief. My eyes have adjusted to the darkness, and I relook at the rust bucket I'd stopped to rest in. This was once a large family car, it still had three child seats in them... and no blood in sight, so I didn't have to imagine anything horrible happening inside it. It showed the ageing that only a vehicle that had stood uncared for in the elements for 14 years could show, but the boot space that I'd fallen asleep in was surprisingly clean.

I think back to my own car and its child seat, only for a split second, because those terrible memories of 14 years ago come rushing back. "My son, my baby boy. I miss you". I sob as quietly as I can, choking back the urge to cry out in pain. It's a strange feeling when you want to live, and want to die, all at the same

time. Although these bouts of despair have become less frequent, the last one being many months ago, they always kick me in the crotch with the exact same intensity. "No parent should have to bury their child" was a common saying from the old world. What about a parent who helplessly watches their child be eaten alive?

I awake with a start. Instantly jolted into hyperawareness.

"You idiot, you fell asleep again!" my brain chides me silently. This time I don't have to wait an eternity. My subconscious has awoken me because it heard that disgusting scraping noise which usually foreshadows death in this horrible world. It is in the distance, about a kilometer away. One has surfaced and is moving along what is left of our paved Perth roads. Not a particularly large one, by the sound of it, so I should be safe as long as I don't move. Being the type that freezes in fear has finally become an evolutionary advantage. In the earliest days it was the runners who perished first, both those who ran away, as well as those who ran towards them.

I clutched at my locket again. I did this at least 30 times a day for reassurance, and to give my fingers something to do. I couldn't stay totally still, it was impossible. My fingers closing around my son's locket, moving it about and playing with it was taking away the stress of my body from being absolute-

ly still. An outlet for all the nervous energy that one generates when in danger, usually accompanied by chicken-skin and hair standing on end.

The silence is shattered with screams. Loud, horrible screams that are so guttural that I can barely recognise them as human. Some poor soul has been found, and they are running fast. The horrific scraping sound gets louder and more high-pitched as the creature accelerates towards its prey. "F***!" I exclaim in my head. "They're coming this way!"

It's a man, I can hear the screaming more clearly now. "Shut up bas****! Stop screaming if you want to live!" I shout to myself in my head. As he gets closer, and as the ground starts to rumble I think to myself, "Will you die already?". He does die, about one second later. Approximately 400 metres from me by the sound of it.

I lay still. It's all I can do. At 400 metres, it will be able to sense the vibrations caused by a loud fart. Running is stupid, it's like throwing blood into the water all around you when trying to get away from a school of sharks. I was going to be here an hour at least, so I fiddled with my locket.

I thought about Dale again, but memories from happier times. Ian had bought me this heart-shaped locket three days after I told him I was pregnant. We decided to choose